

Conflict management

SPEAKING

LEVEL
Advanced

NUMBER
EN_BE_3809S

LANGUAGE
English





Goals

- Can identify and recall some more advanced expressions for managing conflicts.
- Can solve misunderstandings in a variety of difficult and complex situations using these phrases.





Conflict is an inevitable part of our lives
but it doesn't have to be **stressful**.
This lesson will show you how to **manage**
conflict easily.



Conflicts

What kinds of situations are conflicts most likely to arise in?





Conflicts

Have you ever had a **conflict** with
a colleague at work?
How did you **solve** it?





Conflicts

Do you think you are good at conflict management or do you get angry quickly?





Conflict management vs conflict avoidance



TO ESCALATE

- **Conflict management** means ensuring that conflicts **do not get out of hand** and can be solved.
- **Conflict avoidance** means **not solving a conflict** and potentially **making things worse**.



Stop avoiding the conflict – you're making it worse!



What not to do

It is important to try to **manage conflict**, particularly in **work** environments. Below are some things you should **not** do or say when a conflict arises.

- **Overly negative reactions** provoke the same in return and can cause someone to lose face.
- **Placing blame** is unhelpful and makes people go on the defensive.

Overly negative reactions	Placing blame
That's a ridiculous idea!	It's John's fault.
Don't be absurd!	That was Mark's responsibility so we should blame him.
What a load of nonsense!	If something goes wrong, it all comes back to you.



Conflict avoidance

Do you prefer to avoid conflicts or do you take the bull by the horns and face up to problems?





Conflict avoidance

What kind of problems could conflict avoidance provoke?



malicious gossip

bad rumour

secret
simmering
resentment



Conflict

Have you ever been part of a **conflict** that involved the kind of **harsh language** and **blame placing** that was exemplified on p. 8?





How to manage conflict

- Below are some things you should keep in mind when you want to **manage** and **solve** a **conflict**.

I words not You expressions how YOU feel

Focus on the problem and the outcome, not who is to be blamed.

Soften everything you say but still be direct.

Ask for more reasons and focus on giving facts yourself.

Try to find common ground and an outcome which is satisfactory for both parties.





Softening what you say

- It is important to not use **harsh** or overly **direct language** in a **conflict situation**.
- Below are some phrases you can use to **soften your tone** but still remain **direct**.

- I think...
- Maybe...
- I'm afraid...
- Shall we...?
- Let's try...

Let's try to work it out!





Focusing on the problem and common ground

- Here are some phrases you can use to ensure that you remain **focused** on the **problem** and on finding **common ground**.

Focus on the problem	Find common ground
I think this would be a better way to go.	Perhaps we can find a compromise.
Let's try to solve this together.	How about we incorporate both of our ideas?
Unfortunately, that fails to solve the problem.	I appreciate your support and input.
Let's focus on the main issue at hand.	There might be a third position that we are ignoring.



Asking for reasons or clarification

- Here are some phrases that you can use to ask for **clarification** on something or **reasons** for something during a conflict.



Could you expand on your reasons for that?

Please could you rephrase that; I may have misunderstood you.





Calming the situation down

- At times, a **conflict** might **get out of hand**. Here are some phrases you might want to use in such a situation.

Please do not raise your voice.

Would you mind sitting down?

Let's not let this escalate.

There is no reason for us to argue over this.





Saying no

- Here are some phrases you can use to **reject** a colleague's **proposal** or to express your **disapproval** of something.

- We do not condone those methods here.
- We do not want to escalate the situation further.
- Please do not endorse using such methods.
- I'm afraid that is unacceptable.





Dialogue

Read through this dialogue with your teacher. Decide how you would change the dialogue to manage the conflict better.



That's absolutely absurd! There's no way we can agree to repacking the order before Monday.

stubborn/obstinate

Stop being pig-headed and take the blame for this – you're the one who packed the order for shipment.



This isn't my fault. If it's anyone's fault, it's yours. You didn't double check the order before it went out.

You're being ridiculous. I shouldn't have to double check orders because you are incompetent.





Solve the conflict

Conflict resolution uses "I" statements (like "I feel...") to express personal feelings and needs without blame, shifting from "you always..." to focusing on the problem, not the person, fostering understanding and collaborative solutions through active listening, empathy, and negotiation, rather than accusations, to reach mutually acceptable agreements

Look at the situation below and think about the possible ways you could solve this conflict.

■ Your colleague often leaves work unfinished and you have to finish it. Now he/she is asking for a day off next Monday, which is right before the deadline of your current project.



■ Your colleague often takes days off and you never do. You want to take a day off next Monday because your cousin is getting married.





Role play

Now role play the conflict on the previous page with your teacher or classmates. Try to make sure that things do not get out of hand.

I think...



Let's try to find a compromise

Student A or teacher:
You do not want your colleague to have the day off.

Student B or teacher:
You need the day off to go to your cousin's wedding.



Conflict

**Here is another example of a conflict in an office.
Read through it with your teacher.**

Student 1: You promised to make a project successful because you were under the impression that you had a bigger budget for it. You didn't say anything when you received the project because you thought you could make it happen anyway. Now you realise, four days before the deadline, that you cannot complete the project or fulfil the expected quality standards with the allocated budget. You complain to your boss.

Student 2: One of the people in your team agreed to finish a project under a certain budget. Meanwhile, you have already told the client that the project will be completed by a certain date. Now your team member is telling you that he/she cannot finish the project or fulfil the expected quality standards with the allocated budget. However, your client is very picky when it comes to quality. You talk to your team member.





Role play

**You are going to role play another situation.
This time, student B (or the teacher) is going to try to escalate the conflict
and student A (or the teacher) must try to calm him/her down.**

Let's not escalate the situation.



This is ridiculous!

Student A or teacher:
**You agreed to do the project but
now cannot meet the conditions.**

Student B or teacher:
**You are very angry and cannot
control your anger.**



Get ready to listen



The next few pages will focus on your listening comprehension.



Listen and role play

**Listen to your teacher explaining both sides of a conflict at work.
Brainstorm ideas on how to solve this conflict and then role play the situation.**





Listen

Now listen again to your teacher explain a different conflict situation.





Dialogue

Now you are the senior partner of a company and your teacher is an employee. You are going to have a discussion about the dress code. Try to come to a solution which is satisfactory to everyone.

I'm afraid...



Unfortunately...

It's intolerable...



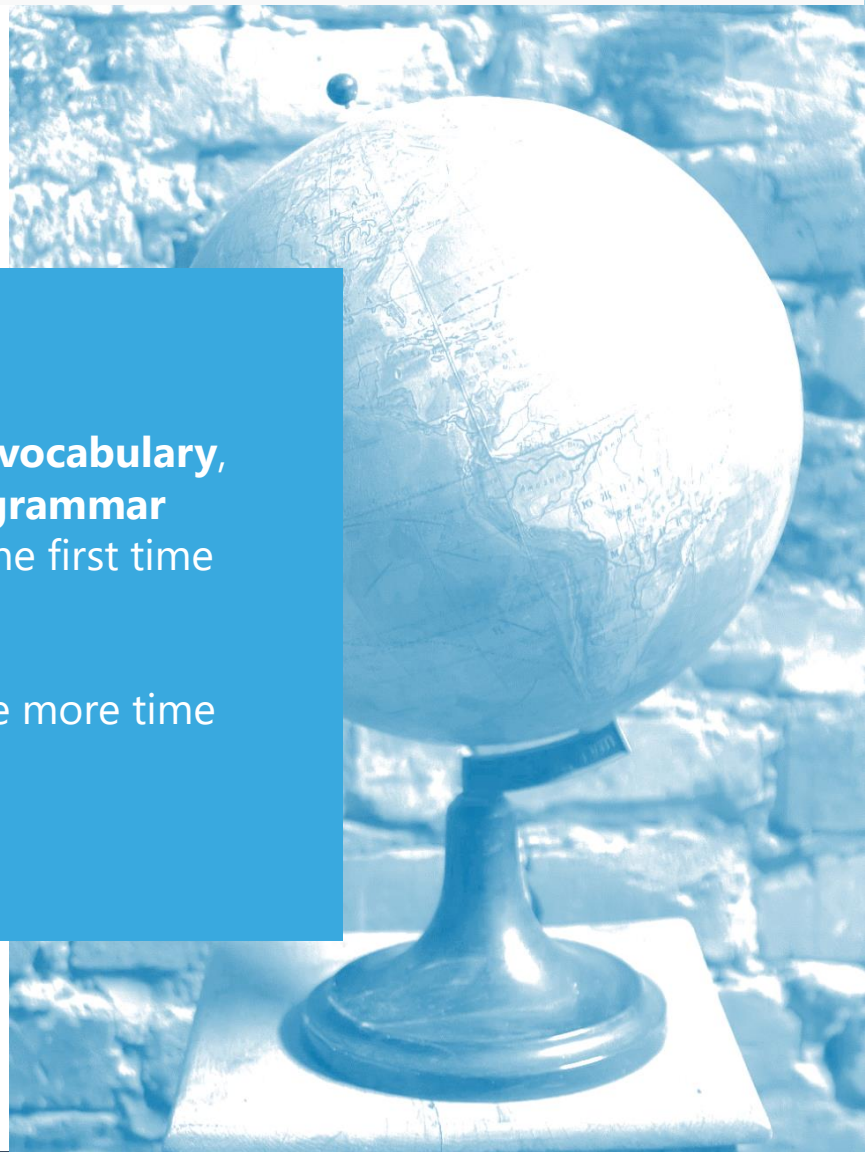
Surely we can...



Reflect on this lesson

Take a moment to review any new **vocabulary**, **phrases**, **language structures** or **grammar points** you have come across for the first time in this lesson.

Review them with your teacher one more time to make sure you don't forget!





Transcription

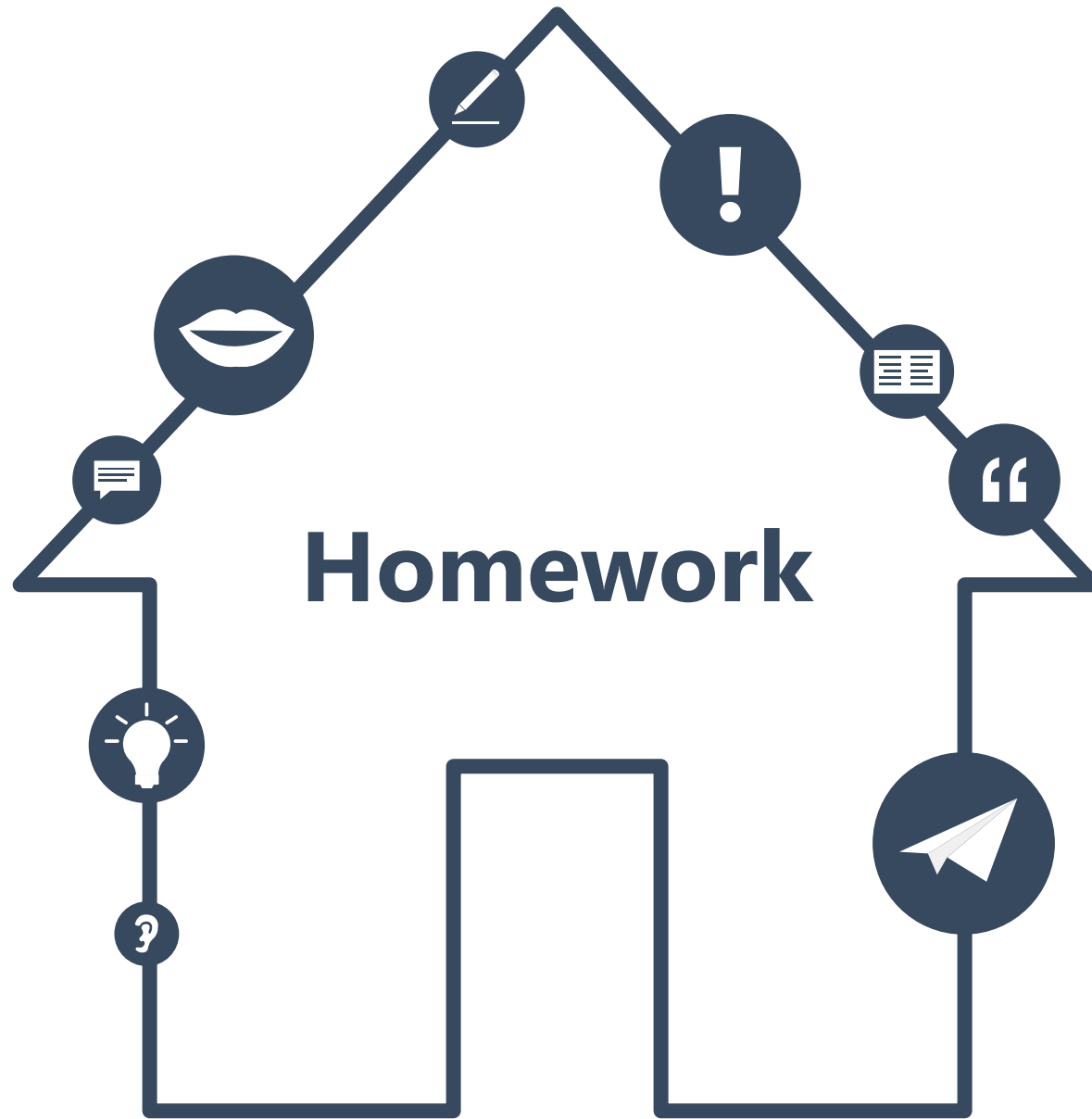
p. 24

Perspective 1: You manage a large team and you have to give performance reviews each year. You have to give a particularly negative review to one person who is constantly late for work. They did ask for flexible working hours last year but you could not grant it.

Perspective 2: You are going to have a performance review and you know there will be a problem over your timekeeping. You have a toddler and need to drop her at nursery every morning. The nursery opens at 8am but you need to be at work by that time. You are about 15 minutes late every day. Last year you explained the situation but could not reach a compromise.

p. 25

You are a senior partner at a large legal firm in London. You have a strict dress code which includes a suit for both men and women, a tie for men, black shoes and no jewellery aside from a wedding ring. The reason you have such a dress code is because you often have clients coming into the office, and people on your teams often have business meetings with clients outside the office. The staff have complained about this restrictive dress policy but you don't feel that you are in a position to change it.





Conflict management

Look at the samples below of things you should and shouldn't do when trying to solve a conflict. What do you remember from the lesson about each of these things?





Writing

Write a bullet point list of tips for conflict management. Try to make this relevant for your current work situation.

○	
○	
○	
○	
○	
○	
○	
○	
○	
○	
○	
○	
○	
○	
○	
○	



About this material

Find out more at
www.lingoda.com

This material is provided by

lingoda



lingoda Who are we?



Why learn English online?



What kinds of English classes do we offer?



Who are our English teachers?



How do our English certificates work?



We also have a language blog!